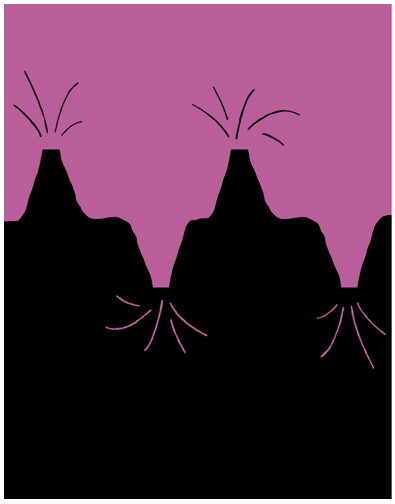


NO VESTIGE OF A BEGINNING, NO PROSPECT OF AN END

UNIFORMITARIANISM

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

James Hutton (1726–97)

BEFORE

1778 The Comte de Buffon, a French naturalist, suggests that Earth is at least 75,000 years old—far older than most people believed at the time.

1787 German geologist Abraham Werner proposes that Earth's layers of rock formed from a great ocean that once covered the entire planet. His followers became known as Neptunists.

AFTER

1802 James Hutton's theory of uniformitarianism reaches a wider audience when Scottish geologist John Playfair publishes *Illustrations of the Huttonian Theory of the Earth*.

1830–33 *Principles of Geology*, by Scottish geologist Charles Lyell, supports and builds on the uniformitarian ideas of James Hutton.

Uniformitarianism is the theory that geological processes, such as the laying down of sediment, erosion, and volcanic activity, occur at the same rate now as they did in the past. The idea emerged in the late 18th century, as mining, quarrying, and increased travel brought ever more geological